Orthodox religious services minister, refused to sign off on the Western Wall compromise, saying that Reform Jews “must not be given a foothold among the people of Israel.” He described the issue in the starkest terms, calling it *yehareg v’al ya’avor*, a cardinal sin, which an observant Jew should die rather than commit. (The Talmud describes just three such sins: idolatry, murder, and sexual immorality.) Another ultra-Orthodox lawmaker, Health Minister Ya’akov Litzman, threatened to resign unless the government moved to “reduce the reformists”. Channel 20, a right-wing television network launched in 2014 to offer programming about Jewish culture, described members of the Reform movement as the bootleg sneakers and fake Rolexes of the Jewish world.

“That’s the disconnect for our young people,” said Denise L. Eger, the president of CCAR. “They hear about Israel and they think science, hi-tech, life-saving medical advancements. And then they hear this other piece, and something doesn’t add up for them.”

One participant made this point to Netanyahu himself during a meeting with the Israeli prime minister. He briefed the rabbis on the regional situation, describing the threats that Israel faced from “medieval” groups like the Islamic State and Hamas. “And I told him, ‘Mr Prime Minister, we have medieval Jews as well,’” the rabbi recalled. “He was silent for a moment. I think he was taken aback slightly.”

Only slightly, though. Tellingly, the meeting with the Reform rabbis was conducted in near-secrecy. Netanyahu met during the same week with the prime minister of Bulgaria and the CEO of Microsoft. He released videos of both. But the prime minister didn’t even issue a written statement about his meeting with the leaders of the largest Jewish community in the diaspora.

Netanyahu decided to postpone implementing the cabinet’s decision, pending further discussion. He convened a group of non-Orthodox rabbis in June; they left disappointed, without any firm commitments from the prime minister. In September the issue went to the supreme court, which heard follow-up arguments to its January ruling. The justices berated the government for “dragging things out endlessly,” and wondered if Netanyahu was hoping for a new decision that would force him to act. “Enough is enough,” said Miriam Naor, the chief justice. “Do you expect us to pull your chestnuts out of the fire for you?”

As this book went to press, more than a year after the cabinet decision, the prayer area still hadn’t been opened. During the High Holidays in 2016,